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A POLITICAL THEORY FOR THE MUGHAL EMPIRE

— A Study Of The Ideas Of Abu'l Fazl

Irfan Habib

Abu'l Fazl's position as the official chronicler of Akbar and as his major counsellor on religious matters is well known. That he had certain ideas on the nature of sovereignty and state policy has also been recognized.¹ But, as I will endeavour to show in this paper, some of his statements in this sphere have not been correctly interpreted, or commented upon; nor have some of his ideas been satisfactorily traced to their sources in earlier thought. Part of the reason perhaps lies in the way Abu'l Fazl wrote. He affects a majestic style, substituting unfamiliar terms for the conventional ones, making it very difficult for the reader to keep him company. Moreover, he tends to make crucial statements in what seemingly are brief asides in the midst of high-flown verbiage; and these tend to be overlooked.

In the paper I aspire to explore both the context in which Abu'l Fazl wrote in terms of ideological inheritance, and the meanings that should be attached to his statements as he makes them. I begin accordingly with his own personal background. Of Abu'l Fazl's life much is known from his own pen,² and from the pen of contemporaries, especially his critic 'Abdu'l Qadir Badauni.³ From later in Mughal times come biographical sketches by Shaikh Farid Bhakkari (1650),⁴ and Shah Nawaz Khan (d.1758).⁵ And there are recent studies as well, notably those by H. Blochmann⁶ and S. Athar Abbas Rizvi.⁷ In view of this rich material, only a short account may be offered of 'Abu'l Fazl's antecedents and career, with emphasis on information more relevant to the formation of his thought.

Abu'l Fazl's father, Shaikh Mubarak (1505-93)⁸ of Nagaur (in Rajasthan), had obtained an orthodox theological education, at Nagaur and Ahmadabad, but had then turned to "sufism and *ishraq* [the philosophy of Illuminated Wisdom of Shihabuddin Suhrawardi *Maqtul*, 1155-91]", and "the truths" of ibn 'Arabi (1165-1240), the Egyptian Sufi poet, ibn Fariz (1181-1235), and ibn 'Arabi's great disciple and interpreter, Sadru'ddin (1203-74),⁹ — precisely the two lines of thought which were to have such influence on the mind of Abu'l Fazl.

Mubarak came to Agra in 1543,¹⁰ where he established a reputation for learning and independence: He did not hide his admiration for "the greatness and mystic status (*wilayat*)" of Saiyid Muhammad of Jaunpur (1443-1505), the founder of the Indian Mahdawi movement, anathema to the orthodoxy;¹¹ and he refused to endorse the theologians' demand

before Islam Shah (1545-54) that the Mahdawi scholar Shaikh 'Alai be punished.¹² In the early years of Akbar's reign he similarly declined to endorse a juridical opinion (*fatwa*) signed by a number of other scholars permitting people to sell their children into slavery, if faced with starvation.¹³ Clearly, Mubarak already combined high theological learning with a spirit of humanism and tolerance. Badauni, however, alleges that Mubarak successively shifted his allegiance to the Naqshbandi and Hamadani orders as these sufic orders obtained popularity (or influence at the court?).¹⁴ But if he did so, this did not protect him from the theologians' persecution, which forced him to turn a fugitive, in or sometime after 1569-70; he was then saved only by the Emperor's compassion.¹⁵

By this time Abu'l Fazl, born in January 1551, had made great progress in his education (mainly received from his father, since he mentions no other teacher), until he reached the age of twenty.¹⁶

It was, then, that, preceded by his elder brother, the poet Faizi (1547-95), Abu'l Fazl obtained access to Emperor Akbar. He soon began to delight the Emperor by contesting the positions of the established theologians in discussions in the Emperor's presence at the '*Ibadat-khana*, at Fatehpur Sikri in 1578-79.¹⁷ His tendency then to criticise and show up the weaknesses of the traditional scholars is noted by Badauni, who also quotes him as saying at that time, "If the Great *Imam* [Abu Hanifa] had lived in our time, he would have written a different law (*fiqh*)."¹⁸ Ultimately, with Mubarak's influence also rising, the leading theologians were forced into signing a declaration (*mahzar*) in 1579, giving Akbar, as a "just Sultan", the power to decide on disputed points of law.¹⁹ Mubarak appended to it the statement under his seal that "this is something I desire with all my heart, and have for years waited for."²⁰

However, this was a document which soon became irrelevant, since Akbar, with Abu'l Fazl as his major confidant in religious and ideological matters, was not content with merely the power to propound and implement a royal version of the *Shari'a*.²¹ The new ideas of religion and the world in general that Akbar now (from 1580 onwards) began to entertain were expressed by Abu'l Fazl in different documents drafted on behalf of Akbar and in his own letters;²² in the official history of Akbar's reign, the *Akbarnama*, that he began to prepare in 1589 and went on extending till his murder in 1602; and in the *A'in-i Akbari*, his description of Akbar's empire, which he formally completed in 1598.²³ A year-by-year, increasingly critical commentary on the new ideological trend at the court is provided by Badauni in his *Muntakhabu't Tawarikh*. Statements on Akbar's ideas, as well as Abu'l Fazl's, appear also in the Jesuit accounts (the Jesuits appeared at Akbar's court as early as 1580).²⁴

By and large, the accounts do not contradict each other.

It is to be observed that the dominant influences which led to the formulation of the new views by Akbar and Abu'l Fazl came from within the Islamic tradition.²⁵ Perhaps, the most significant influence was derived from ibn 'Arabi. We have seen how Mubarak had read the works of ibn 'Arabi and the writings of Sadru'ddin; but Akbar received the teachings of that master from yet another source in the late 1570's. Shaikh Taju'ddin, who "in the knowledge of Unity was a second ibn 'Arabi", conveyed in night sessions knowledge of the matters of "Unity of Existence" (*wahdat-i wujud*) and "Perfect Man" (*insan-i kamil*) to the Emperor.²⁶

It is true, as modern critics point out, that ibn 'Arabi's theory does not amount to simple monism, or pantheism.²⁷ But, however "transcendental" the Unity, once its Reality is recognized,²⁸ the differences seen in the sensory world are bound to lose their significance and become illusory. From this a world-view followed, which Abu'l Fazl describes while introducing Akbar's spiritual views in his *A'in-i Akbari*:

When world-ornamenting wisdom-giving God desires that the essence (*gauhar*) of humankind should come into existence, and from the diversity in the degree of (spiritual) capacity, the cloud of Duality (*do-rangi*) rises and fashions Religion (*din*) and World (*dunya*), every creature begins to have a distinct leader (*kar-giya*), and these become engaged in mutual denunciation. As lack of vision and unwisdom become the touchstone, the knowledge of (true) worth and acquisition of love become scarce. Otherwise, what is Religion, what is World? There is one heart-ensnaring Beauty which casts splendour through many thousands of veils. They have spread an expansive carpet, and it sheds forth many different colours.²⁹

This passage may be treated as the starting point of Abu'l Fazl's political thought. Both religion and the secular sphere ("world") are placed at par, and as equally illusory, being products of a false Duality. This immediately liberates temporal sovereignty from any dictates of theological doctrine.

So freed from any sectarian, religious roots, Abu'l Fazl can then locate the basis of sovereignty in the needs of the social order. Here his reasoning first follows the pure dictates of reason ('*aql*'), appealing to the tradition of the philosophers (*filasafa*) and the scientists (*hukama*'). In a sense, ibn 'Arabi's thought could be used to justify tolerance of reason as of other dissentient or contradictory elements. In the *A'in* Abu'l Fazl takes special care to stress his knowledge of the classical Graeco-Islamic scientific tradition; and a tradition hostile to him records that he had brusquely brushed aside Ghazali's criticisms of the scientists with the short remark that Ghazali "had spoken nonsense".³⁰

It is, therefore, not surprising that Abu'l Fazl appeals to a theory of social contract to justify the necessity of political authority. In a chapter entitled 'The Provision of Livelihood (*Rawai-i Rozi*)', he says:

Whereas abundant differences are embedded in the nature of humankind, and disturbance, internal and external, is of daily growth, and huge desires speed fast and anger is quick to break out, in this demon-land of unmanliness, [therefore] friendship is scarce and justice absolutely non-existent. In all circumstances, in such a place of tumult, relief is not possible except through the punitive power of a single man (*qahri-i wahadat*). That life-saving medicine cannot be provided except through the terror (*shikuh*) of just rulers. When a house or inhabited quarter cannot be administered without the fear or hope from a perspicuous head (*peshwa*), how is it possible for the disturbance of the world's nest to die down without that recipient of Divine Light (*paziranda-i farr-i Izidi*) [the righteous ruler]³¹ and how would the property, life, honour and religion of the world's people be protected?³²

He then goes on to argue that the effort of some "recluses" (*tajarrud-gazinan*) to appear as "breakers of old customs" (*khariq-i 'adat*), and remedy the troubled state of affairs was unsuccessful because of lack of support from "exalted Sultans." This is obviously a dig on prophets trying to be sovereigns on the basis of their creeds, especially keeping in mind the Islamic experience. Indeed, in such arid conditions ("burning desert" — *atishin dasht*), the tricksters (*tilism-kar o nairanji o sha'bada baz*) have a field day, the innocent being submerged in "storms of tumult", and the wise coming to be denounced as "mad, irreligious and infidels." A theocracy cannot, therefore, but lead to further disturbance.

It is only "a just ruler (*kar-giya*)" who is able "to convert, like a salt-bed, the impure into pure, the bad into good;" but he can do so only by gathering "loyal helpers, a large wherewithal for grandeur and a large treasury." Soldiers were particularly necessary: "the self-loving base ones (*firo-mayagan-i tabi'at-parast*) cannot listen to the voice of reason, and cannot go beyond their (immediate) senses; and in such saline ground, the water of the sword works, not the wholesome water of argument."

Accordingly, "the wages of protection" (*dast-muzd-i pasbani*) have to be paid to the sovereign for protecting the four "essences" (property, life, honour, religion). For such task no wages or taxes could be too high, but "just sovereigns do not take more than what suffices for their task and do not soil their hands by desiring more."³³

This doctrine justifies temporal sovereignty, but assumes two classes of sovereigns, just and unjust. How a just sovereign should be identified and how he should function are matters that Abu'l Fazl takes up elsewhere at the very beginning of the *A'in-i Akbari*.

In this discussion, a third element clearly enters, the influence of the *ishraq* theory. Developed by Shihabuddin Suhrawardi *Maqtul* (d.1191), whose writings were universally read in the Islamic world, its origins went back to Plato's *Republic*, where the Good is presented under the symbol of the Sun. The Sun becomes for the *Ishraqis* a symbol of God-derived spiritual lights, the *anwar-i qahira*, each of which "from degree to degree, illumines the presence of each lower degree" (H. Carbin).³⁴ Abu'l Fazl uses the imagery, even the terminology of the *ishraq* tradition, when he puts temporal sovereignty at the highest station in the hierarchy of objects receiving spiritual light: "To the Unique Almighty, there is no higher station than that of the King (*Padshah*)... Royalty is a light from the Inimitable Almighty and a ray from the world-illuminating Sun, the essence of the books of perfection, the assemblage of excellences. In the language of the day it is called *farr-i Izidi* (divine light); in the ancient [Iranian] language, *kaihan-khwura* (world-illuminating light)."³⁵ Thus even if the sovereign is not a product of any religion, he yet has authority from God. Abu'l Fazl refrains from using the conventional Muslim adjective for the ruler, *zill-i Ilahi*, God's shadow. The sovereign is rather a recipient of divine light,³⁶ possessor of illumined wisdom, and the reflector of the light received.

But not all worldly sovereigns receive such light. We have seen that Abu'l Fazl, in speaking of just rulers, implies another category, that of unjust sovereigns. He now blames the simple-minded ones (*salim-dilan*) for not distinguishing the "godly ruler" (*farmanfarma-i haqiqi*) from the self-seeking aspirant for authority (*peshi-ju-i khwud-kam*). Since both have at their command treasure, army, subjects, scholarly servants, numerous craftsmen, and personal attendants, discrimination between the two kinds of sovereigns can only be made by the enlightened ones. They realise that the rule of the "godly" rulers is long-lasting and marked by peace, justice, etc.; the tenure of the selfish ones short-lived and marked by terror, cruelty, theft, etc.³⁷

It was clearly the just ruler to whom the title of *Padshah* was appropriate and who could be the recipient of God's light. As a courtier and, perhaps, sincere admirer, Abu'l Fazl held Akbar to form a class by himself; and when he speaks of *Padshah* and accords him a special station near God, he surely has Akbar as a unique ruler in mind. The concept of the "Perfect Man" in the ibn-'Arabi tradition would certainly be very useful here, as Badauni suspected.³⁸ But there was another possible source for justifying the exaltation of a particular individual, namely, the doctrines of Mahmud Pasikhwani (d.1427-28), the originator of the Wahidiya or Nuqtawiya sect.³⁹ These beliefs had reached Akbar at the critical moment when he was fashioning his new ideas in association with Abu'l Fazl. In

1577 Sharif Amili, after a chequered career, joined his court, and he was a follower of Mahmud Pasikhwani.⁴⁰ Mahmud believed in a kind of metempsychosis through the meeting of the physical elements of a former body to create a new one, this being in his case, "a more perfect being" than Muhammad, whose elements too had come together in him.⁴¹ One could then also claim for Akbar an eminent status on the basis of these speculations.⁴² It is, however, fair to say that if Mahmud's theory of great spiritual souls born at particular periods exercised any influence on Abu'l Fazl, he does not either directly or indirectly himself show such influence anywhere, though he seems to have had good relations with the Iranian Nuqtavis.⁴³

In fact, in Abu'l Fazl's view, the true or "godly" king was rather to be recognized by the functions that he carried out. We may dispense with the display of qualities of strong will, God-worship, quickness in giving relief to seekers, etc., which Abu'l Fazl enumerates for him. The two important functions that Abu'l Fazl assigns to such a sovereign, are religious tolerance and respect for Reason, twin major departures from mainstream political thought in Islam.

The first requirement, he says, is "the fulfilling [by the sovereign] of the obligations of being father (*pidari*) of mankind: Different kinds of persons receive comfort from his benevolence and out of the diversity of religion the dust of duality does not rise forth".⁴⁴ This is the tolerance of conflicting faiths, which Abu'l Fazl subsumed in the term he and his master so often used, viz., *Sulh-i kul*, 'absolute peace'.⁴⁵ This concept invoked directly ibn 'Arabi's philosophy. The higher form would be *muhabbat-i kul* ('absolute love'), when presumably the transcendental unity would be absolutely recognized. For those who could not achieve it, the path of *Sulh-i kul*, the tolerance of all diversity, was prescribed.⁴⁶ *Sulh-i kul* was doubtless something to be pursued and achieved by an individual; in his autobiography Abu'l Fazl lists his success in "attaining *Sulh-i kul* through the favour of His Majesty's attention". This consists he says, "sometimes" of turning from speech to silence, sometimes making friendship (*ashti*) with good men of all communities (*har ta'ifa*), and ultimately, accepting excuses, making peace (*masaliha*) with the bad".⁴⁷ For the ruler, *Sulh-i Kul* meant a policy of tolerating all religious (and other) differences. Abu'l Fazl describes how beginning from 1578-79, Akbar, adopting the position of *Sulh-i kul*, opened a discourse with leading men of all religions (including Christians and Brahmans) and appointed men of different faiths to high office (such as the Shi'ite Iranis, the Sunni Turanis and the Hindus) and quietly faced up to the uproar of denigration and denunciation that arose from the orthodox.⁴⁸

Since *Sulh-i kul* was a philosophical principle difficult for many to follow, Abu'l Fazl also offered a more popular Let's-leave-it-to-God argument to justify religious tolerance, which he put into the regulations (*dasturu'l 'amal*), drafted for the Emperor in or some time after 1584. All officials were enjoined to be vigilant in pursuing religious tolerance since royalty and authority mean the giving of protection to all: "they should not object to (the practising of) the faith and religion of the people, for when a wise man does not risk loss in this mortal world, why should one risk loss in the realm of religion which is eternal? If the truth (*haqq*) is on his side, you will be opposing and objecting to the truth; if the truth is with you, and he has, out of ignorance, chosen a position opposite to it: he is a hapless victim of the illness of ignorance; he deserves compassion and assistance, not objection and opposition. Remain friendly (therefore) with the good people of every sect (*har giroh*)".⁴⁹

There is no doubt that the urge for the pursuit of *Sulh-i kul*, as state policy, owed much to the position of Mughal empire, situated in a multi-religious country. It accorded closely with the patriotism for "Hindustan" which both Akbar and Abu'l Fazl were so frankly encouraging.⁵⁰ Religious tolerance, which to Barani had seemed an unworthy compromise, could now be proclaimed an essential function of the state, required by the highest principles of mystic truth.

The second function of the state is given at this particular point in such a brief sentence that it tends to be missed: The true, the just sovereign, we are told, "shall not seek popular acclaim through opposing reason ('*aql*)".⁵¹ We have seen that despite Abu'l Fazl's extensive use of *sufic* concepts and beliefs, he remained steadfast in his allegiance to reason and science. One major factor here was the opposition that rationalism offered to orthodox traditionalism, regarded by Akbar as his major enemy. Abu'l Fazl quotes among Akbar's 'happy sayings' the following:

The case for pursuing reason ('*aql pazhohi*) and rejection of traditionalism (*taqlid*) is so clear that it does not need any argument from me. If tradition is to be held excellent, all prophets would have just followed their ancestral customs.⁵²

Abu'l Fazl himself gives a spirited condemnation of *taqlid* when he lists reasons why Indian beliefs and culture had not been more closely studied by Muslims:

The fifth [reason], the blowing of the heavy wind of *taqlid* (tradition), and the dimming of the lamp of *khirad* (reason, wisdom). Of old, the door of 'how and why' has been closed; and questioning and enquiry have been deemed fruitless and the act of a pagan (*kufr*). Whatever one received from one's father, teacher, kinsman, friend and neighbour was considered the wherewithal of Divine favour; and the holder of a

contrary opinion was accused of heresy and impiety. Though some of the enlightened have tried a little to pursue a different path, yet they have followed the path of (correct) conduct no more than half-way.⁵³

Abu'l Fazl's stout espousal of the protection of rationalism by the state looks odd when we see him making use of mystic theories and speculations to justify the system of despotism envisioned by him — a benevolent one, it is true, but despotism all the same. There was little intrusion of reason in the formulation of the basic premises or detailed elements of either the *ishraq* or ibn-'Arabi traditions; and *sufis* of all shades had been one with the theologians in denying the autonomy, let alone the supremacy, of the realm of reason. Abu'l Fazl's obvious theoretical weakness is that he never comes to grips with this contradiction, and makes no attempt to resolve it. This shows up, perhaps, a real weakness in the rationalism that he was defending. It seems that Abu'l Fazl had hopes that the realm of reason would expand under the protection that Akbar's State was providing to it — he took delight in the fact that his son 'Abdu-r Rahman, "though an Indian by birth, has a Greek temper (*mushrib*)", that is, a philosophical or scientific bent.⁵⁴ But the generations after Abu'l Fazl remained barren, and even the discoveries of Europe's Scientific Revolution remained undiffused in India. There was thus little rationalism in India any way that the State could have either suppressed or protected.

III

It is worthwhile, perhaps, at the end to compare Abu'l Fazl with an earlier writer, whose ideas have been supposed to furnish a political theory for the Delhi Sultanate.⁵⁵ Both Barani and Abu'l Fazl have elements in their thought that are peculiarly their own and not derived from any known external source. Barani's dual anxiety that the state should respect and protect the *status-quo*, especially the existing composition of the ruling class, and that the work of terror should be contained, especially in relation to groups of status, had been generated by his own interpretation of the internal history of the Delhi Sultanate.⁵⁶ These coloured his perception of the contemporary state, whose moral justification he could see chiefly in the fulfilment — partial, if expediency so directed — of the dictates of the *Shari'a*, in respect of the external enemies (Hindus) and internal subverters (philosophers). Much of the actual practice of the Sultanate had been the opposite of what he desired of it, whether in containing its violence or in fulfilling its obligations to the *Shari'a*, and was obviously as far from his ideal state as any polity could be.

With Abu'l Fazl, the position is the reverse. The Mughal Empire as constructed by Akbar and as governed by him, after he had raised "the veils" in c.1579-80,⁵⁷ was the ideal state. There was certainly much in

his regime to justify this beyond the claims of a courtier: a certain compassion, a restraint in the operations of its punitive apparatus, a systematization taken to the extent of creating a quasi-constitution, a degree of religious tolerance found in few other countries at that time — it could even convert a critical modern author into its admirer.⁵⁸ It seemed to meet and rectify the two main concerns of Barani: stable hierarchy and containment of violence. These matters no longer trouble Abu'l Fazl; he is far more concerned with other objects of the State.

Where Barani is deeply conscious of the fact that the real basis of the State lies in force,⁵⁹ Abu'l Fazl locates it in a species of social contract and the divine-illuminated wisdom of the mystic tradition. The State's objectives, as he sees them, are, therefore, different from what Barani sets for it. All subjects, whatever their faith, have equal claims on its benevolence; and reason, not theology, is to be the arbiter. One may doubt Abu'l Fazl's speculative and mystical premises, while Barani's insistence on force as the sustaining factor for the state, is certainly far more realistic. But if Abu'l Fazl's basic assumptions are possibly dubious, the duties he nevertheless derives therefrom for the State are surely unexceptionable, even glorious. Some "illuminated wisdom" must surely have been at work, when he penned his loyalty to *sulh-i kul* and 'aql, to religious tolerance and reason, so firmly over and over again.

NOTES AND REFERENCES

1. Saiyid Athar Abbas Rizvi provides a scholarly discussion of Abu'l Fazl's 'political thinking' in his *Religious and Intellectual History of the Muslims in Akbars' Reign (1556-1605)*, New Delhi, 1975, pp.352-73; but he seems to miss out some of Abu'l Fazl's really bold propositions, such as his rejection of a theocratic regime and his espousal of a species of social contract.
2. Abu'l Fazl's own autobiography at the end of his *A'in-i Akbari*, ed. H. Blochmann, Bib. Ind., Calcutta, 1867-77, II, pp.258-83, is very inadequate on his own career, but there are scattered references to himself in his *Akbarnama* (the history of Akbar's reign), ed. Agha Ahmad 'Ali and 'Abdu'l Rahim, Bib. Ind., Calcutta, 1873-87, esp. vol.III.
3. See his *Muntakhabu't Tawarikh*, ed. Ahmad 'Ali, Kabiru'ddin Ahmad, and W. Nassau Lees, Bib. Ind., Calcutta, 1864-69, Vols.II and III, passim.
4. *Zakhiratu'l Khawanin*, ed. S. Moinul Haq, Karachi, 1961, I, pp.67-77.
5. *Ma'asiru'l Umara* ('Abdu'l Hai's recension, 1780), ed. 'Abdu'r Rahim and Mirza Ashraf 'Ali, Bib. Ind., Calcutta, 1888-91, II, pp.608-22, which combines Farid Bhakkari's account with information drawn from other historical sources.
6. In the initial portion of his translation of the *A'in-i Akbari*, I, ed. D.C. Phillott, Bib. Ind., Calcutta, 1972, pp.xxv-lix.
7. Rizvi, op.cit., esp. pp.76-140, 339-73, 455-98.

8. The dates are as given by Abu'l Fazl in the *A'in*, II, pp.260, 276.
9. Ibid., p.261.
10. Ibid., p.262.
11. Badauni, *Muntakhabut-t Tawarikh* [hereafter cited by author's name only], III, p.67: Badauni recalls here a conversation in which he defended Shaikh Mubarak during the period 1556-60, when he himself was a student of Mubarak.
12. *A'in*, I, pp.264-5. Badauni, III, 74, even alleges a friendship between Mubarak and Shaikh 'Alai.
13. Badauni, III, pp.68-9.
14. Ibid., III, pp.74. He says that Mubarak thereafter turned to favour the 'Iraqis, by which Badauni means the Shi'as; but whether this was before or after he obtained access to the court is not made clear.
15. *A'in*, II, pp.266-75.
16. Ibid., II, pp.276-78.
17. Badauni, II, pp.262-63. A letter exists from Mubarak to Faizi, expressing some anxiety over the hostility that Abu'l Fazl was exciting by his debates among "the black-hearted greybeards" (the theologians) by his use of arguments from the sciences, both rational and scriptural ('ulum-i 'aqli o naqli) that Mubarak himself had taught him (*Majma'u'l Afkar*, [selection from an 18th-century collection of documents], ed. Iqtidar Husain Siddiqui, Patna, 1993, pp.22-23).
18. Badauni, II, pp.262-63; III, p.79.
19. The text of this declaration is given in Nizamuddin Ahmad, *Tabaqat-i Akbari*, ed. B. De, Bib. Ind., Calcutta, 1913-35, II, pp.344-46; and in Badauni, II, pp.270-72.
20. Badauni, II, p.272.
21. In the *Akbarnama*, I, p.269, Abu'l Fazl comments that the power and function of *ijtihad* or interpretation of Law, assigned by this *mahzar* to Akbar, suited "a status inferior to His Majesty's person".
22. *Mukatabat-i 'Allami* or *Insha'i Abu'l Fazl*, in three parts (*sih daftar*), collected by 'Abdu's Samad (1606-7), many editions: Calcutta, 1810, etc. I have used the Nawal Kishore ed., [Lucknow?] 1864, (cited hereafter as *Insha'-i Abu'l Fazl*), which is edited with glosses by Muhammad 'Ali.
23. For the relationship between the *Akbarnama* and the *A'in-i Akbari* and the dates of their undertaking and completion, see Shireen Moosvi, *The Economy of the Mughal Empire, c. 1595*, Delhi, 1987, pp.2-8.
24. The main Jesuit sources (rendered in English) are: *Letters from the Mughal Court: the first Jesuit Mission to Akbar (1580-1583)*, ed. John Correia-Afonso, Bombay, 1980; *Commentary of Father Monserrate*, transl. and ed. S.N. Banerjee and John S. Hoyland, Cuttack, 1922; and Fr. Pierre du Jarric, transl. C.H. Payne, *Akbar and the Jesuits*, London, 1926.
25. It was, indeed, noted by Aziz Ahmad, *Studies in Islamic Culture in the Indian Environment*, Oxford, 1964, p.179, that Akbar's "Divine Faith shows a surprising indifference to Hinduism".
26. Badauni, II, pp.258-59.
27. Cf. Henry Carbin, *Creative Imagination in the Sufism of Ibn 'Arabi*, transl. Ralph Manham, London, 1969, pp.203 & ff.
28. See *ibid.*, pp.186-88.

29. *A'in*, I, p.158. Blochmann's translation of this passage (I, pp.170-71) is surprisingly inaccurate; he so misreads the entire substance of the passage that it must be entirely discarded.
30. I have discussed Abu'l Fazl's attachment to reason and science in: 'Reason and Science in Medieval India', *Society and Ideology in India, Essays in Honour of Professor R.S. Sharma*, ed. D.N. Jha, New Delhi, 1996, pp.167-69; Abu'l Fazl's outburst against Ghazali is related in Muhammad Rahim Kishmi, *Zubdatu'l Maqamat*, Lucknow, A.H.1302, p.131.
31. On this, there will be a comment further on.
32. *A'in*, I, p.290.
33. *A'in*, I, p.290-91, for the original text from which this and the previous two paragraphs are drawn. The reader must be warned against depending for the these passages on H.J. Jarrett's translation (*A'in-i Akbari*, II, revised by Jadunath Sarkar, Calcutta, 1949, pp.54-56), which is particularly inept here.
34. Quoted in R. Arnaldez, 'ISHRAK', *Encyclopaedia of Islam*, New ed., IV, Leiden, 1978, pp.119-20. J.F. Richards has already drawn attention to the connexion between the *Ishraqi* ('Persian Neoplatonic') theory of Illumination and Abu'l Fazl's play on Light (J.F. Richards, ed. *Kingship and Authority in South Asia*, Madison, 1978, pp.260-67; summarized in his *Mughal Empire*, Cambridge, 1993, pp.45-47).
35. *A'in*, I, p.2. Abu'l Fazl surely has in mind here the passage in Shihabu'ddin Suhrawardi's *Partau-nama* ('Book of Radiance', ed. and transl. Hossein Ziai, Costa Mesa, Calif., 1998, p.84): "Whoever knows wisdom and is assiduous in praising and revering the 'Light of Lights' (*Nuru'l Anwar*), as we have stated, they give him the 'kingly light' (*khurra-i kayani*) and bestow upon him the 'luminous ray' (*farr-i nurani*); and the 'lightning-flashing (cloud) of God' (*bariqi-i ilahi*) clothes him in the robe of authority and status" (my own rendering). Can one say that Abu'l Fazl has in fact inverted Shihabu'ddin's assertion? Whereas the latter argued that the person with spiritual attainments achieves the supreme status, the possession of "kingly light", for Abu'l Fazl it is the just king who possesses not only the "kingly light" but also the highest spiritual attainments.
36. We have seen above how Abu'l Fazl calls the just sovereign, *paziranda-i farr-i Izidi* (*A'in*, I, p.290).
37. *A'in*, I, p.2.
38. Badauni, II, pp.258-9. The central position of *al-insan al-kamil* in the realm of existence was particularly defined and elaborated by Sadru'ddin Qunawi, the major disciple of ibn 'Arabi (W.C. Chittick, 'Sadr al-Din Qunawi', *Encyclopedia of Islam*, New ed., VII, Leiden, 1995, p.754, col.2.)
39. A fairly extended account of the founder and his sect is given in Mobad (c.1655), *Dabistan [-i Mazahib]*, ed. Qazi Ibrahim, Bombay, A.H.1292, pp.243-47. See also H. Algar, 'Nuktawiyya', *Encyclopaedia of Islam*, new ed., VIII, Leiden, 1995, pp.114-17.
40. See Badauni, II, pp.247-8. Badauni claims to have read, and been revolted by, Mahmud's tracts, thirteen in number. For *nuqtavis* at Akbar's court other than Sharif 'Amili, see *ibid*, III, pp.204-7, 378-9.
41. *Dabistan*, p.244.
42. Sani Khan Hirawi, for example, is said to have envoked Mahmud Pasikhwani's predictions for fixing on A.H.990 (A.D.1582) as the year when "the promised person" (*shakhs-i ma'hud*) would appear. (Badauni, III, pp.206-7). This would have suited

Akbar.

43. In a *farman* to the Nuqtawi scholar Safiu'ddin Ahmad Kashi, Akbar refers to Abu'l Fazl's favourable opinion of Darwish-Khusrau, the principal Nuqtawi leader in Iran (copy printed in Khaliq Ahmad Nizami, *Akbar and Religion*, Delhi, 1989, pp.379-80). The *farman* is dated '4 Azar 94', where 94 must be a mistake for 34 [*ilahi*], and the year of issue is therefore 1589. Darwish-Khusrau was executed by Shah 'Abbas I in 1593, and Ahmad Kashi not long afterwards.
44. *A'in-i Akbari*, I, pp.2-3.
45. Cf. M. Athar Ali, 'Sulh-i Kul and the Religious Ideas of Akbar', *Studies in History*, New Delhi, IV(i) (1982), pp.27-39; and Iqtidar Alam Khan, 'Akbar's Personality Traits and World Outlook — a critical reappraisal', *Akbar and his India*, Delhi, 1997, pp.79-96.
46. *Farman* of 26 November 1590 to A'zam Khan, in respect of Jains (Mohanlal Dolichand Desai, *Jain Sahityano Samkshipt Itihas*, place (?), n.d., reprod. of *farman* (copy), facing p.545). The *farman* bears all the marks of Abu'l Fazl's penmanship.
47. *A'in*, II, p.279.
48. *Akbarnama*, III, pp.271-73. And not only from the orthodox Muslims. Fr. Monserrate, member of the first Jesuit mission, accompanying Akbar to Kabul in 1581, says distastefully that Akbar "cared little that in allowing every one to follow his own religion, he was in reality violating all religions" (*Commentary*, p.142).
49. *Insha'-i Abu'l Fazl*, p.61.
50. Cf. M. Athar Ali, 'The Perception of India in Akbar and Abu'l Fazl', in *Akbar and his India*, ed. Irfan Habib, Delhi, 1997, pp.215-224. But *Sulh-i kul* was not seen as a doctrine solely applicable to India. Obviously disturbed by 'Abbas I's religious persecutions, Akbar wrote in a letter (January 1595), drafted by Abu'l Fazl, urging him to practise *Sulh-i Kul* (*Insha'-i Abu'l Fazl*, p.31; *Akbarnama*, III, pp.659-60).
51. *A'in*, I, p.3.
52. *A'in*, II, p.229.
53. *A'in*, II, p.3. To be fair, Akbar and Abu'l Fazl did not hold *taqlid* to be restricted to Muslims. For criticism of Akbar's minister Todar Mal on account of his attachment to his idols, by way of *taqlid*, see *Akbarnama*, first version, Br. Mus. Add.27,247, f.291a; also the final version, Bib. Ind. ed., III, p.221.137. Cf. *A'in*, II, p.281.
54. Cf. *A'in*, II, p.231.
55. Cf. Mohammad Habib and Afsar Umar Salim Khan *Political Theory of the Delhi Sultanate*, Allahabad, n.d., being a translation of selected portions of Ziya Barani's *Fatawa-i Jahandari*, with an important interpretive introduction.
56. Cf. Irfan Habib, 'Barani's theory of the History of the Delhi Sultanate', *Indian Historical Review*, VII (1980-81), pp.99-115.
57. Cf. *Akbarnama*, III, p.268.
58. M. Athar Ali, Presidential Address ('Mughal Empire in History'), *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, 34th session, Muzaffarpur, 1972, pp.175-88.
59. Cf. I. Habib in *Indian Historical Review*, VII, pp.103-106.